

JOSE VALENCIA EDITED

Travel Radio Australia, we're in the Valencia region this month and I'm speaking with the promotion executive for the Valencia Region Tourist Board and it's Jose David Aledo and Jose, welcome to the program. Thank you, thank you very much. Now Jose, Valencia is such a beautiful region in Europe, can you tell us a bit about it, where it is for those people who've never been? Of course, Valencia, we are a region located on the south-east part of the country, south-east part of Spain, so we are on the shores of the Mediterranean.

There are like three main areas in the region, let's say the north part of the region is called Castellón, central part is called Valencia and the south part is called Alicante, so we have direct flights from most of the countries in Europe into Alicante and Valencia airports, so it's very convenient and very easy access. The capital of the region is Valencia, which is the most well-known city in the region and it's the third biggest or largest city in Spain, after Madrid and Barcelona. We have very good connections with the rest of the country by plane, also by fast train, so the infrastructure is really, really good.

The region, as we are the Mediterranean, we have very mild weather, let's say that in the winter time we have an average temperature of around 14-15 degrees, so it's a perfect destination to enjoy any kind of outdoor activity, including golf. We have like around 30-34 golf courses in the region, most of them are in the south part, in the area of Alicante, which is also known as Costa Blanca, but also we have golf courses around the city of Valencia and in the north, in Castellón. And apart from that, the region of Valencia is very well-known because it's the home of paella, maybe you have heard about this.

Oh, certainly I've had it and they make it a lot here in Cannes too, it's a very big dish here in Cannes. It's like one of the most popular dishes in Spain and the origins are in the Valencia area, actually in the surroundings of Valencia city. We have a lot of rice crops, rice fields, and that's the origin of this dish, right? We have some other attractions such as the local festivals like the Fallas de Valencia, which is very popular in Spain.

It's this festival in the month of March when we build this type of sculptures made of papier-mâché and wood and we set them on fire on the night of the 19th of March. All the regions have different festivals that are very popular in Spain. As I said, the region has very mild weather, we have a great coast, great beaches, a lot of music festivals all year round, so it's a very, very interesting place to see and visit.

Now, I've been to Alicante myself, I did a bit of filming there once and it was so beautiful in the mountains, that's absolutely gorgeous, isn't it? When you get up to those beautiful villages and looking down on the villages, absolutely superb. It is, it is. When you come by plane you can see, as you said, as you mentioned, you can see the small villages that are inland surrounded by the mountains.

Even though the region is very known because of its coast, we have very cosy small villages inland that offer all type of outdoor activities such as trekking, hiking, mountain bike, so it's also very attractive for this type of tourism. I always ask this, what a couple of favourite places, maybe a bit out of the way, not so touristy, but people want to go and visit, they can really feel the real feeling of Valencia. Okay, there are some small villages by the beach that are not so well known as some others, such as, for example, Villa Joyosa, which is a small beach near Benidorm, which is like the big resort in the Costa Blanca.

This one, Villa Joyosa, is very close, but it's not so very well known and it's very beautiful because it's the sea view, the front view of the houses is really very special because they are all colourful houses. Those are the former fishermen houses that are all coloured in different colours. Other places, such as the city of Alicante, has special corners that not many people know.

People that go to Alicante usually stay at the area of the beach, but there is an old town in Alicante city that is also not very well known. It's on the, beside the castle, there is a castle on top of the hill in the city of Alicante, and beside the castle there is this small neighbourhood all with old white houses, all with these plants and flowers that is also very nice to visit. And we're here in Cannes at the International Golf Markets, and tell us a bit about the golf courses in the region too.

We have, as I mentioned before, we have more than 30 golf courses in the region, like 20 of them are in the south, in the Costa Blanca, Alicante, and some others around the city of Valencia and Castellón. We have courses for all type of golfers. We have Jack Klaus design courses, we have Severiano Ballesteros, Chema Olazabal, Robert Trent Jr. design, so we have, we can cover all type of clients.

And also all, some of, most of these golf courses are in golf resorts that offer to the client all type of services, some of them in the city, some of them by the beach, so we cover all type of clients. We're speaking with José David Aledo, who are from the Valencia Regional Tourist Board, and José, how can people find out more online about your region? Yes, we have a website translated in different languages, English of course, and you just need to regionofvalencia.com and you will find all the information about the region and the golf courses and the rest of the offer. Thanks so much, and we all look forward to visiting Valencia and having a bit of paella with the locals.

That will be great. Thank you for your interview.